

Some of the textiles printed with vegetable dyes

Rescuing a lost craft of India

MADRAS.

An intrinsic part of Indian tradition, the art of vegetable dyeing and printing on cotton cloth, arose out of deliberate experiments with plant alchemy. The variety of motifs and designs that are in usage, speak for the hoary heritage of this craft.

The advent of synthetic dyes and mechanised processes in the textile world displaced hundreds of thousands of workers engaged in this craft. In Madhya Pradesh in four districts alone, about 5000 families were practising this craft. Until the early decades of the century these craftsmen were even exporting fabrics to countries abroad. Their number has now dwindled to about 500.

The Crafts Council of India, a voluntary organisation, has been actively involved in rescuing the many lost crafts of India over the past several years, and has helped to restore these crafts to a position of economic viability through its exhibitions, sales and demonstration programmes. The Council recently organised an exhibition of vegetable dyed hand printed fabrics from Madhya Pradesh at the Lalit Kala Akademi, Madras.

While the printing community has received sporadic support from the Government over the past few decades, Mr. T. C. Jethmalani who has been actively involved in promoting this craft said the traditional art is dying because not enough has been done to study its problems. "Pumping in money will not provide the answer", he said.

Though the process takes about three weeks, the results are well worth the effort. Treated fabrics are first printed with blocks made of seasoned teak wood, then washed in running water, after which they are carefully dried in the sun and then dyed with vegetable dyes. The printing is done with alum paste and ferrous sulphate paste and the dyeing is done with materials such as haldi, aal and katha. All the dyes that are used are natural and the colours remain fast. The cost as well as maintenance of the fabrics are comparable to those that are machine produced. Mr. Jethmalani pointed out that while the craft is labour intensive, it does not require high capital investment. Its revival and promotion would bring down the costs further and it could prove to be a useful supplementary source of income for rural families in many parts of India. — Our Staff Reporter.

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